

Music on tap

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Tune in to listen to your kind of music, anytime of the day, any day of the year, anywhere on earth—just tune in to Internet radio

In the good old days of the last century, before TV was king and when computers were made of vacuum tubes, you could crank up the radio and tune in to music, sports, debates and news through the airwaves. Back then, this was how history came alive—be it World War II or when the first man landed on the moon. Radio Ceylon and Vividh Bharati reigned supreme before the television boom of the 1980s and the emergence of FM radio.

Today, though tuning into a radio channel of your choice is easier, you still have to search for a good station. And then, no commercial radio station transmits what you want, all day long. This is where the Internet comes to the rescue. For some time now, the more demanding among us have been tuning in to Web-based radio stations. The Internet boasts of thousands of radio stations, making it the ultimate user's market. With Internet radio, you don't need to hunt down the frequencies or look up programme guides—you are never restricted by frequencies and time. You don't need any extra high-tech gear either; most of what is needed is already on your desktop.

Gearing up the radio shack

You will need to have a few software tools installed to hear your tunes online—a player for the common formats that are streamed over the Internet is required. You will also need a plain dial-up modem to connect you to the Internet. As far as formats and players go, some stations broadcast in Real Audio and others stick to Windows Media Audio. In this context, you have Shoutcast, a system that delivers live audio or audio-on-demand for archived broadcasts. It uses the MP3 format for audio delivery. Some stations also broadcast proprietary formats and for these you would be required to download their players. Discussed below are some of the more popular streaming formats.

Real Audio and Windows Media

RealNetworks's Real Audio (www.real.com) was a dominant format in the initial days of Internet radio stations.

It is designed explicitly for streaming and is still very popular as a streaming format. Despite being one of the oldest formats around, Real Audio has been constantly improved upon by its designers.

To listen to Real Audio-based broadcasts, you need to install the RealOne player, which also lets you play Real Media video files.

The Windows Media Audio (WMA) format is another excellent format for streaming audio. With recent improvements in the underlying technology, it results in very good sound quality (refer to the article, 'Play it again Sam' on page 82).

WMA files can be played with Windows Media Player (www.windowsmedia.com) that comes bundled with Windows. You may need to install a newer version though, to take advantage of the improved technology. WMA is steadily becoming a popular

Windows Media Player 7
Find it on the Playware CD
RealOne Player, Winamp 2.81, Radio@Netscape Plus Player

Find them on the Mindware CD



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Philips has introduced the world's first streaming audio system, the Streamium MC-i200 that connects to the Internet via a broadband connection